amount of Rs 700 on Gill. After the decision, Bajaj stated that her stand had been vindicated, while Gill resolved to appeal and pursue his legal remedies until his dignity was restored.[31]

In eight years, judicial opinion about the strength of Bajaj's case had turned, but public opinion had not. The chief judicial magistrate observed in his judgement that Gill could not be treated as any other common citizen, prompting criticism that he had been singled out by virtue of his public profile.[32] The largest English newspapers took editorial positions that were sympathetic to Gill, and in some instances also blamed Bajaj for Gill's indiscretions. Twenty-four hours after the judgement was pronounced, the *Indian Express* took the following editorial line: 'No Indian who is aware of his role in defeating secessionism in Punjab can be happy at Gill's misfortune . . . Unfortunately it is not his humiliation alone; the country too feels a little small today.'[33] Forty-eight hours later, the following appeared in the *Deccan Herald*'s editorial pages: 'It somehow makes the law of the land look grotesquely odd and incongruous that a man who has done signal service to the country by ridding a state of the dread and oppression of terrorism should have to spend five months in jail for a minute's exuberance provoked by the charms of an attractive working woman.'[34] (It should have been 'three months', but that was hardly the most disturbing aspect of the piece.) Seventy-two hours later, it was *The Hindu*'s turn to defend Gill: 'The sentence of three months' rigorous imprisonment . . . although well within his discretion and powers under the relevant section of the Indian Penal Code looks somewhat harsh considering that Gill had an outstanding record as a supercop. If today Punjab is rid of militancy which had taken a heavy toll of human lives in the state a great deal of the credit goes to Gill.'[35]

In the endless cycle of decisions and appeals, it was now the sessions court's turn to determine whether to uphold the judgement of the chief judicial magistrate. (In the judicial hierarchy, appeals from the chief judicial magistrate are to the sessions court, appeals from the sessions court are to the high court, and appeals from the high court are to the Supreme Court.) In January 1998, Sessions Judge Amar Dutt upheld Gill's conviction, but